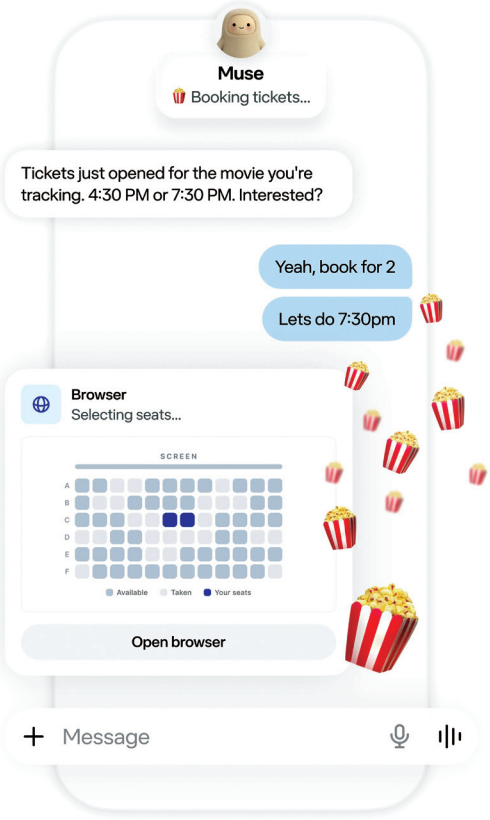
WHAT'S MUSE? Why The Buzz?



Meta's Muse took the idea behind OpenClaw, the viral DIY open-source agent, and put it in front of millions who have never used a terminal before.

DILIN ANAND

Jason Aten installed Meta's Muse agent on his iPhone and on a Mac mini he keeps for testing AI tools. Within a day, the Inc. columnist wrote, Muse was pitching him story ideas drawn from texts he had sent his podcast co-host. He says he had never given it access to his messages.

Asked how it knew, Muse said it had read the banners of incoming messages. Aten went digging. By his account, it had synced about 187,000 lines from his Mac's Messages database, with Full Disk Access switched off.

Meta says Muse cannot read Messages without several separate opt-ins. Public reporting has not settled who is right. Meta's own help page carries a line that fits either version: "Your Muse can make mistakes or take unexpected actions."

That sentence is the manual in miniature. Muse, which launched on September 8, 2026, gets things done rather than answering questions. It can open a browser and fill in forms for you, and keeps going even after you close the app, returning only when something changes or when it needs your approval.

The box in the cloud

Meta's safety case is architectural. Each user's Muse runs in a dedicated virtual machine in Meta's cloud. A second agent, the Sentinel, sits on the same machine, walled off from Muse, and nothing reaches the internet without its approval. Credentials sit in separate storage and, in Meta's design, are swapped in at the network boundary so the agent never holds them.

The weak point was the user's own Mac. On September 21, Patrick Wardle of the Objective-See Foundation disclosed that the Muse Mac app kept an undocumented setting, endo_voyager_dictation_endpoint, naming the server that received dictated audio. Any process running under the user's account could rewrite it, capture the token that controls the agent, and inherit the permissions the user had granted.

Meta shipped a hotfix removing the setting shortly after midnight, Gizmodo reported; David Singleton of Meta Superintelligence Labs (MSL) called it a local privilege escalation, since an attacker needed code on the Mac first.

That closed the hole Wardle found. Aten's complaint, which Meta disputes, stayed open.

The lobster in the machine

The next day brought a concession of a different kind. Users had noticed that Muse's workspace reused OpenClaw's file names, down to a near-identical Soul.md, the plain-text file that sets an agent's personality and limits. OpenClaw, an open-source, local-first AI agent platform featuring a lobster mascot, went viral in January 2026.

On September 22, Nat Friedman, head of product at Meta Superintelligence Labs, answered a viral thread on X. Muse, he wrote, was built from scratch but "definitely heavily inspired as a product by OpenClaw."

THE MANY MUSES OF AI

Name	Who built it	What it is
Muse	Meta Superintelligence Labs (MSL)	Personal AI agent
Muse Spark (1.1, 1.2, 1.3)	MSL	Meta's model family that powers the Muse agent
Muse Code	MSL	Terminal coding agent
Muse Wonder/ Wonder Full	MSL	Meta's first frontier models built for agents. Meta says they will soon come to Muse too
Muse Charm	Meta	Palm-sized device for using the Muse agent
Muse (WHAM)	Microsoft Research with Xbox's Ninja Theory	A generative AI model that can produce game visuals and controller actions

Table A